MUMBAI-AHMEDABAD HSR: PROGRESS REPORT

State of the bullet train project as on June 30

BRIDGES

River bridges completed: **68% (17 of 25)**

Steel bridges completed: **50% (14 of 28)**

STATIONS

Total stations: **12**

Finishing works under way at: **8 (all in Gujarat)**

UNDERGROUND TUNNEL

Completed: **24% (5 km of the 21-km BKC–Shilphata tunnel, Maharashtra)**

MOUNTAIN TUNNELS

Completed: **1 (in Valsad, Gujarat)**

Breakthrough achieved: **3 (of 7 in Palghar, Maharashtra)**

TRACKS

Track bed completed: **41% (209 route-km)**

Track slabs manufactured: **39% (198 route-km)**

Track slabs laid: **17% (85 route-km)**



IANS

which BEML was tasked with developing two prototype trainsets, designated B28, for Rs 886.87 crore. Designed for a top speed of 280 kmph, the prototypes are expected to be ready by early 2027. "Finally, India will have to run trains that can reach speeds of upwards of 300 kmph. This is more a stopgap arrangement. And if Japan wants to supply trainsets, it will have to manufacture for the system (ETCS) that is in use the world over," says Seth.

THE JOURNEY AHEAD

With the major technology choices now settled, the National High Speed Rail Corporation Ltd (NHSRCL) is clearing the decks for the Cabinet to decide on the seven HSR corridors announced in this year's Union budget, including Delhi-Varanasi and Chennai-Bengaluru. Estimated to cost about Rs 350 crore per km, the projects are likely to rely on a mix of financing models, including possible World Bank assistance.

"The USP of any HSR network is its ability to convert what are now occasional, planned journeys into long-distance daily commutes," says a senior NHSRCL official. "That, in turn, means relying increasingly on non-fare revenues such as commercial development."

Another unresolved issue is operations. Few organisations anywhere have experience running a commercial HSR network. Discussions are under way on appointing an Operations and Maintenance contractor, with names such as the Delhi Metro doing the rounds. The Japanese, too, have been informally encouraged to explore partnerships with Indian firms and enter the fray. At the same time, the NHSRCL has invited global rolling stock majors to present their capabilities for developing the B35—an indigenous bullet train designed for a top speed of 350 kmph (320 kmph operational) and intended as the standard platform for all future HSR corridors. India is also putting in place a two-stage safety certification regime, with third-party international auditors clearing the trains before final approval by a government body.

Where does Japan fit in now? "The Japanese team has indicated that E10 is under development. It will be introduced simultaneously in India and Japan. The timelines and other contractual terms and conditions are under discussion," says Vaishnaw. That shift was evident during Japanese PM Sanae Takaichi's visit to New Delhi in early July. Compared with previous joint statements, this one read like a diplomatic tightrope walk. "Japan fully understands India's target to commence commercial operations on priority sections in 2027 and remains committed to extending the necessary cooperation. They (the respective premiers) acknowledged the goal of introducing the E10.... They also expressed willingness to explore possible ways to cooperate on future high-speed corridors." Notably, there was no mention of signalling. Those in the know say there were some backroom talks on whether to include E10 at all.

The Japanese embassy did not respond to queries from INDIA TODAY. But, in May, speaking while announcing the financial results of JR East—a key Japanese technical advisor on the Mumbai-Ahmedabad project—the company's vice president, Atsuko Itoh, reiterated that the safety standards associated with Japanese bullet trains could not be guaranteed if they operated with European signalling. She also said that negotiations with India had been difficult.

Whether or not those differences are eventually resolved, India is determined to not let anything come in the way of its HSR ambitions, enabled by initial Japanese financing if not its signalling systems or trainsets. For the Modi government, this seems to be a dream that must come true, whatever it takes. ■